A Family Conversation About This Month, Not Five Years From Now

What Dad needs today, and what each of us can keep doing.

At family dinners, somebody always has a view on where Dad will be in five years. One of you is sure nothing will need to change. Another has a timeline in mind. Nobody has asked what help he gets this month, and nobody has asked him.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: a single account of the help Dad gets today and what each of you can keep doing. It isn't for forecasting, and it isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Dad, first. It's his week being described. Then everyone who helps with anything: the one who does the Saturday shopping, the one who phones every evening, the neighbor who brings in the trash cans, if Dad would like her there. Someone who lives far away can join by phone or send notes ahead.

Choose an ordinary day and a place where Dad is comfortable. His own kitchen table is fine. Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with Dad, and with a question about now. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. [1]

- “Dad, nothing's wrong and nobody is planning anything. We'd like to write down how your week works, and we want your version first.”
- “Each of us sees a different bit of your week. Can we put it together on one page?”
- Say what the conversation is for: one account of today. Say what it isn't for: guessing the future, or deciding where anyone lives.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. What does an ordinary week look like for you, start to finish?

2. Which things do you do yourself and want to keep doing yourself?

3. Where is a hand useful now, and is there any help you'd rather not have?

4. If something changed one day, how would you want us to bring it up with you?

Ask each other

1. What do you do for Dad now, and how often?

2. What can you realistically keep doing, and what would make it hard?

3. What have you seen Dad do for himself lately that the rest of us might not know about?

4. Which changes would each of us want to ask a professional about, and whom would we ask?

How to write down what was said

Keep Dad's own account separate from what the family says. Where two people see something differently, write both and don't settle it. A view about the future goes down as a question, with the name of the person it's for.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	ABOUT TODAY, OR ABOUT LATER?	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
"I do my own breakfast and my own laundry. I'd be glad if someone else did the gutters."	Dad	Today	
Saturdays are fine for the shopping, except when work travel comes up.	Marcus	Today	
"I wonder about the stairs."	Tracy	Later. A question for his doctor or a therapist.	Dad says the stairs are fine

What not to decide yet

None of these is for today, and some of them take an assessment. Write them down as questions and leave them open.

- Where Dad will live, now or one day.
- Whether his help will need to change, when, or to what.
- Whether he should have someone with him at particular times.

- Who is right about the future.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes, date them and send them around, to Dad first.
- Who will take each question to his doctor, a therapist, his pharmacist or your care consultant.
- When you'll look at the page together again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement about the future or tell you what a professional will say. It gets the family, Dad included, to one dated account of today, with the differences left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one account of this month now, with Dad's version at the top. The care interview takes it further: it asks about every area of his daily life, including the ones that are fine right now, and turns the answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?